PREHENSILE-TAILED PORCUPINE

Coendou prehensilis

Think About This

If your tail could grab branches like a hand,

What can it see, hear, or feel?

Long whiskers feel for branches at night, its nose finds food, and its ears catch sounds from below.

Where does it live — and why?

It lives in the top of the rainforest, sleeping in high branches and eating leaves, bark, and fruit.

How does it send messages?

It raises its quills, turns sideways to look bigger, and moans or hisses at predators.

What does it do when something changes?

By day it stays hidden and still; at night it wakes up and climbs to a different tree.

How does it learn?

A single baby stays with its mother and learns which trees to visit before foraging alone.

How does it have babies?

A mother has one baby with soft spines that harden in hours, and it can grip branches right away.

What are its limits?

It cannot jump, so when trees are cut down, it loses the branches it needs to travel.

What does this teach us?

Never needing the ground, this animal is shaped entirely by the trees above.